

Veteran Readiness & Employment (VR&E) How-To Guide

This guide outlines key points of emphasis regarding the VR&E (Chapter 31) program through the Department of Veterans Affairs. This includes how to apply, eligibility requirements, regulatory support, roles and responsibilities, and guidance for overcoming barriers in pursuit of a vocational goal. For further support or a 1-on-1 discussion of your case, please refer to the M28C Manual or contact your local VR&E representative.

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Before you Apply:

1. Before applying, identify a specific and feasible vocational goal. This allows your VRC to assist you more effectively. Remember, VR&E is an employment-focused program, not a general education benefit.
 - a. Developing a goal, such as a doctor, lawyer, computer programmer, heavy equipment operator, whatever it may be goes a long way to working through the program.
 - b. Your vocational goal must be feasible. An example of a vocational goal that is not feasible is saying after 20 years of military service and no medical experience without completing an undergrad, you want to be a Physician. This path may require 8+ years of training, often starting in your late 30s, which makes feasibility under a 48-month limit unlikely.
 - c. The vocational goal must also be within your skills and aptitudes. There are many ways to show this, either through standardized testing, previous work experience, or if you are interested in the long term employment track, enrolling in a graduate program.
 - i. Only use educational or vocational training programs that meet the following: They are mandatory based on generally accepted hiring practices. (Example: Juris Doctor degree for a Lawyer, master's degree: Psychology for a practicing psychologist, Medical Doctorate for a Physician.
 - ii. It helps to already be in the program, if you are not in the program refer to the Employment Through Long-Term Services section.
2. Second thing is determining your Employment Handicap:
 - a. You have an employment handicap if you meet one of the following and have a minimum VA rating of 20%:

- i. An employment handicap is generally easy to explain and justify. If you are transitioning from the military and any your Service Connected Disabilities limit your job selection.
 - ii. Your VA rating increased due to an aggravation of your service connected difficulties and need to change careers and are limited on which careers you can choose because of your service connected difficulties.
 - iii. Your VA rating has not changed, and you have not used VR&E services before but your current job aggravates your Service Connected Disabilities.
 - b. Your initial VR&E appointment is focused on determining this. Communicate with your VRC what disabilities affect you. You do not need to relate all your SDCs to your Employment Handicap (EH), just mention the key ones that are relevant to your situation.
 - c. Being determined eligible for VR&E services is not the challenge for most vets, it is the approval process for the Vocational Rehabilitation Goal and the development of the Individual Written Rehabilitation Plan (IWRP).
3. Build out your own plan:
 - a. Outlining your own plan, to include doing your own market research and vocational exploration helps a lot for getting your VR&E claim approved. Suggested pre-meeting research:
 - i. Three job postings for positions that have the same requirements as your vocational goal.
 1. Any job posting network works
 - ii. Digital print outs of Department of Labor and O*NET outlooks for your vocational goal.
 1. Your vocational goal should have longevity; the goal is to only use VR&E once.
 - iii. Your own resume
 - iv. Transcripts from previous education and training.
 - v. If you are currently in a program, and looking to receive retroactive induction you will want the following:
 1. Invoices from the program
 2. Admissions Letter/Current Transcripts
 3. Course Curriculum
 - vi. All of these help provide your VRC with critical information.
4. Things to do to ensure your VR&E Claim is properly updated.
 - a. You will be asked to provide key documents to support your Vocational Goal and Individual Written Rehabilitation Plan (IWRP), the two ways to ensure all of your documentation is properly added is to either reply to the “EVA” email (the email address that sends you VR&E appointment verification emails), or to upload the documents via the [QuickSubmit Portal](#). Instructions for the [QuickSubmit Portal](#) are in the Appendix of this document.
5. **DO NOT LET A VR&E Employee convince you to reapply somewhere else.**
 - a. **Any time you reapply, you are essentially opening an appeal without filling out the necessary documentation. This allows your VRC to close you out and pass your claim to someone else to handle. This increases their numbers, without providing you the assistance you require.**

How to Apply:

1. Log in to [VA.gov](#)
2. Complete and submit [VA Form 28-1900](#) (Application for Vocational Rehabilitation), or apply using this [link](#).
3. If you're still on active duty and awaiting discharge or have initiated a claim, submit [VA 28-0588](#) to request a memorandum rating.

1. Veterans applying for the Getting Ahead after Get Out program must be within the last 180 days of Active Duty.
2. Submit the form for VR&E under the [QuickSubmit Portal](#)
4. Await scheduling for your **initial evaluation appointment** with a Vocational Rehabilitation Counselor (VRC).
5. You must attend a group orientation prior to scheduling your initial counseling with your VRC. This is a group meeting via Zoom. If you miss the orientation twice, you will be disenrolled from the program and must reapply.

Program Eligibility:

You may be eligible for VR&E if you:

- Have a service-connected disability **rate at least 20%** by the VA.
- Have not overcome your employment handicap.
- Are within your **12-year eligibility period**, unless exempted.

Determining Employment Handicap

Per [38 CFR § 21.51](#), a VRC must find:

1. **Vocational impairment** exists.
2. **SCDs contribute substantially** to that impairment.
3. The veteran **has not overcome** the effects of the impairment through training or employment.

Key Factors Considered:

- Limitations from SCDs or NSCDs
- Lack of current, relevant training or licensure
- Gaps in employment
- Barriers to job placement

A clear link between your SCDs and your employability limitations is essential. Determining an Employment handicap is easy, where most veterans struggle is the approval of a vocational goal. Many VRCs will attempt to sell a veteran on a lower threshold for a vocational goal, or state that you are employable for a profession that is below the threshold of the vocational goal you desire.

Automatic Entitlement (MEB/IDES Cases):

- Active duty servicemembers pending discharge due to SCDs may qualify for **automatic entitlement** under [PL 110-181](#).
- Submit [VA Form 28-0588](#) and initiate an application prior to discharge.

VRC Responsibilities & Duty to Assist

Per [38 CFR § 21.33](#) and **M28C Part IV**, your VRC is legally required to:

- Assist you in developing evidence for entitlement.
- Assist you in your vocational exploration.
- Guide you in defining a suitable vocational goal. (They do not get to determine your vocational goal for you).
- Assess employment feasibility based on your SCDs.
- Help select an institution or training program that best meets your needs to achieve a vocational goal
- Inform you of your appellate rights if your claim is denied.

If you believe your VRC is not assisting appropriately, **request a Higher-Level Review or contact their supervisor.**

Rehabilitation Tracks:

VR&E offers five distinct tracks to support your vocational goal:

1. [Re-Employment](#) – Return to your pre-service position.
2. [Rapid Access to Employment](#) – Immediate job placement.
3. [Employment Through Long-Term Services](#) – Vocational training or graduate education. The requirement is that this training must meet generally accepted credentialing or hiring practices (i.e. JD degree for a Lawyer).
4. [Self-Employment](#) – Starting your own business.
5. [Independent Living](#) – Support for veterans unable to work.

Employment Through Long-Term Services

- [M28C.IV.C.2.05c](#): The employment through long-term services track is targeted to claimants who need long-term services, such as remedial or refresher courses, specialized training, and/or post-secondary education, to obtain and maintain suitable employment.
- [M28C.IV.C.4.02a](#):
 - A plan for employment through long-term services provides a claimant an extended period of training and rehabilitation services to ensure that the claimant acquires the skills necessary to obtain and maintain suitable employment.
 - This track is provided to a claimant who may need extensive training or education and necessary rehabilitation services to overcome his or her impairment of employability. Services may include, but are not limited to, remedial or refresher courses; specialized training; post-secondary education; on-the-job training (OJT); non-paid work experience (NPWE); apprenticeships; and other necessary rehabilitation services.

Training and Institution Selection:

According to **38 CFR § [21.120](#)** and **[21.294](#)**:

- You may choose any institution that is approved for GI Bill (Ch. 30/33 – Montgomery GI Bill/Forever GI Bill (formerly known as the post-9-11 GI Bill)) use.
- The **VRC has final authority** on facility selection but must collaborate with the claimant.

- If multiple institutions meet your goal, **cost can be a factor**, but:
 - A more expensive institution may be justified if it provides superior support services, disability accommodations, is fit for the timeline of attendance, or has higher job placement outcomes.

High Cost Programs:

- If program costs exceed **\$50,000 annually**, a **High-Cost Memo** must be developed.
- High-cost approval must be obtained **before** finalizing a rehabilitation plan.

Program Costs Approval Levels (per M28C.V.B.1):

- **VRC:**
 - Rehabilitation plans with annual costs of up to \$50,000, except for the following rehabilitation plans:
 - Self-employment plan
 - Independent living plan
 - Extended evaluation plan
- **VR&E Officer (VREO):**
 - Rehabilitation plan with annual costs of \$50,000 to \$75,000
 - Retroactive inductions
 - Individualized Extended Evaluation Plan (IEEP) with program costs that exceed \$25,000
 - Rehabilitation plan that contains the VR&E Housing Adaptation Grant with costs up to the SAH limit
 - Rehabilitation plan with program costs of up to \$2,000 that includes construction using Acquisition
 - IILP with program costs of up to \$75,000 for a calendar year and does not contain construction
 - Self-employment plan with program costs of up to \$49,999
 - Reimbursement for the purchase of a firearm
 - High Dollar Invoices ([38 CFR § 21.430](#))
- **Regional Office (RO) Director:**
 - Rehabilitation plan that exceeds the program costs of \$75,000-\$100,000 per calendar year
 - IILP with program costs of \$75,000 to \$100,000, and does not include construction
 - IILP that includes construction costs between \$2,000 and \$15,000 using Acquisition
 - Reimbursement for the purchase of a firearm
- **Executive Director of VR&E Service:**
 - Rehabilitation plan with program costs that exceed \$100,000 per calendar year
 - Self-Employment plan with program costs that exceed \$49,999

- Rehabilitation plan that does not include IL construction costs of services that exceed \$100,000 per calendar year using Acquisition
- Rehabilitation plan that includes IL construction costs that exceed \$15,000 using Acquisition
- Rehabilitation plan that includes a VR&E Housing Adaptation Grant that exceeds the SAH grant limit
- IILP that exceeds the 36-month period

Note: These figures represent **program costs only** and do not include subsistence allowance. Costs include tuition, fees, books, and supplies provided directly through the rehabilitation plan.

Supporting your Case: Evidence & Occupation Requirements

- Vocational Exploration is used to gather information to make informed decisions about a Vocational Goal:
 - **M28C.IV.B.2.01**: Definition of Vocational Exploration: Vocational exploration is used to assist the claimant in selecting a suitable vocational objective that is consistent with his/her abilities, aptitudes and interests, and does not aggravate his/her disability(ies). If the claimant has transferable skills and/or training or experience in a suitable occupation, the same or a similar occupation must be considered prior to exploration of occupations requiring additional training.
 - Use **O*NET**, **OOH**, or **DOT** to support your vocational goal. These are not the be-all and end-of vocational exploration; they are tools to help you, as the veteran, make an informed decision.
 - An SOC is a career category. Do not accept a less qualified career within the SOC containing a career that best aligns with your vocational goal.
- Document barriers caused by your SCDs that prevent or limit you from working in prior or related fields. Most of us who have service-connected disabilities cannot choose whichever job we want. That is an employment handicap.
- If you are currently employed, your justification hinges on how your current job exacerbates your service-connected disabilities.
- VRCs must outline whether your disabilities limit your ability to perform physical and cognitive duties required by target occupations.

Retroactive Induction:

- **M28C.V.B.6.03**: Retroactive Inductions for a Period Previously Completed via Self-Pay states that the requirements for reimbursables due to self-paying for services when you would have been eligible if not for being on active duty are reimbursable. VR&E will reimburse you for necessary and justified expenses during the Retroactive Induction period.
- **M28C.V.B.6.04**: Retroactive Inductions for a Period Previously Completed Under Chapter 33 states that all previously paid for expenses under title 33, when you would have been eligible if not for being on active duty, are reimbursable. VR&E will reimburse your GI bill for months previously used.

Travel:

38 CFR [§ 21.370](#) and [§ 21.372](#) authorize VR&E reimbursement at the government rate for mandatory travel to attend approved training.

- **[§ 21.370](#)** covers intraregional travel. There are currently 56 regions aligned in 5 districts. Regions are identified [here](#).
 - If the training program is required for your vocational goal, the VR&E is required to reimburse and pay for mandatory travel expenses to and from the training facility.
- **[§ 21.372](#)** covers interregional travel. There are currently 56 regions aligned in 5 districts. Regions are identified [here](#).
 - This follows the same guidelines as above, except it requires regional offices to coordinate.

Definitions to Know (Glossary):

- **Employment Handicap (EH):** SCD causes substantial vocational impairment.
- **Serious Employment Handicap (SEH):** More significant, often justifying extended or advanced training.
- **Suitable Employment:** Matches aptitudes and abilities, does not worsen disabilities, and is stable.
- **Stable and Continuing Employment:** Same or similar position for 3–5 years.
- **Vocational Impairment:** Limitations from disabilities, education gaps, employer attitudes, or market barriers.
- **Feasibility:** Determination that your rehabilitation goal can be achieved given your current or developable skills.
- **Service Connected Disabilities:**
- **Other definitions:** [M28 Glossary](#)

Final Notes:

- The VR&E program exists to support veterans in returning to the workforce in meaningful, sustainable ways. **You do not need to accept a lower-quality option if a higher-quality program better addresses your limitations and improves your employment outcomes.**
- If you encounter resistance, request clarification in writing, reference this guide and the cited regulations, and assert your right to review or appeal.
- If a VRC asks you to produce documentation such as failed job applications, select jobs you are already qualified for, or something that does not align with you achieving your vocational goal, ask them, **“Why?”** Vocational exploration is a general but not all-encompassing guideline. If you already know your vocational goal, stick to it.
- You are eligible for this support due to your service; use it fully and confidently.

Helpful Resources:

- **YouTube Channel:** [I Am Nic The Vet](#) – Army Veteran documenting her journey through the VR&E process.
- **M28C:** [Here](#)
- **38 CFR Part 21:** [Here](#)

APPENDIX A: QuickSubmit Portal

You will login using whichever method you use to log into va.gov

[AccessVA Home](#) | [About AccessVA](#) | [Contact Us](#)



Choose a secure VA Partner to sign into QuickSubmit:
Don't have one? [Register for a Sign-In Partner](#) or [Learn More](#)

Note: We're moving to a simpler and more modern sign-in experience. We'll remove the DS Logon option after September 30, 2025. [Learn more about creating a Login.gov or ID.me account.](#)

	Sign in with DS Logon		Sign in with DoD CAC Card
	Sign in with VA PIV Card		Sign in with ID.me
	Sign in with LOGIN.GOV		

Select another
VA website

The main portal will show your submission history and allow you to search based on the below fields for previously submitted documents. You are able to upload new documents by selecting the Blue “Upload Documents” Button.

Upload History



[Search Direct Upload Archives](#)[Export Search Results](#)

Date From	Date To	Upload Conf. #	Current Stage
 mm/dd/yyyy	 mm/dd/yyyy		Select... ▼
CM Packet	Benefit Claim Type	Organization (Type to filter and select)	
	Select... ▼	Select... ▼	
File Number/SSN	Veteran ICN	Veteran First Name	Veteran Last Name
Zip/Postal Code			
	SearchReset		

Submission Date	Upload Conf. #	Current Stage	CM Packet	Benefit Claim Type	Organization	File Number/SSN	Veteran
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On the Upload Documents portal, you will see your identifying information, and a drop-down menu to the right. There you are able to select which department you wish to submit documents to. These documents will be automatically added to your claim with that department.

1. The department you will choose for this purpose is Veteran Readiness and Employment.
2. You'll select the "Choose Files to Upload" or Drop Files Here option.
3. You will need to follow the below guidelines to ensure that your submission is properly processed:
 1. Maximum of 30 files per upload.
 2. Files cannot contain any special characters, only letters, numbers and spaces.

Upload Documents

Veteran Information

First Name

MI

Last Name

Veteran File Number/SSN

Veteran ICN

Veteran ZIP Code

☐ International Veteran

Submission Information

Benefit Claim Type

Veteran Readiness and Employm... ▼

Attach Files i

Choose Files to Upload

 or Drop Files Here

Files

minimum 1 file required

File Name	Status	File Size	Action
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